Edilwasif Tapsiril Baddiri

Edilwasif Tapsiril Baddiri (born December 13, 1975) is a Filipino jurist, lawyer, and public servant of full Tausug descent, currently serving as an Associate Justice of the Court of Appeals of the Philippines.

He was appointed to the appellate court by President Ferdinand Marcos Jr. on February 24, 2025, and took his oath of office before Chief Justice Alexander G. Gesmundo on April 11, 2025, filling the seat left vacant by retired Justice Edwin D. Sorongon.

A product of Ateneo de Manila's law faculty and Harvard University's Kennedy School of Government, Baddiri brings to the bench not only elite academic credentials but also decades of ground-level legal work, from defending indigent clients in Sulu to presiding over a busy Metro Manila trial court.

He is widely recognized within the Bangsamoro legal community as the fifth Tausug jurist to reach the Court of Appeals, a milestone that carries deep symbolic weight for a people long underrepresented in the national judiciary.

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BACKGROUND

Edilwasif Tapsiril Baddiri was born on December 13, 1975, and is a full-blooded Tausug, an indigenous ethnic group native to the Sulu Archipelago in the southern Philippines.

The Tausug, whose name translates roughly to "people of the current," have long maintained a proud tradition of political and legal autonomy rooted in the Sultanate of Sulu, one of the oldest Islamic polities in Southeast Asia.

Growing up in the cultural and socio-political landscape of Sulu shaped Baddiri in ways that went well beyond the personal. He came of age in a region grappling with armed conflict, political marginalization, and the slow, uneven progress of the peace process between Manila and the Bangsamoro people. These realities became the invisible curriculum behind his formal education.

His middle name, Tapsiril, reflects his maternal lineage, a quiet but meaningful marker of family heritage in Tausug naming tradition.

While the details of his immediate family life are kept private, consistent with judicial security norms, those who know Baddiri describe his personal life as a balanced synthesis of demanding legal professionalism and steadfast Islamic faith. He is known in legal circles for integrating his identity as a Muslim Filipino into his practice not as a talking point but as a genuine orientation toward justice.

EDUCATION

Baddiri pursued his undergraduate and legal studies in Manila, and in 2000 he earned his Bachelor of Laws (Ll.B.) from the Ateneo de Manila University School of Law, one of the Philippines' most competitive and respected law programs.

At Ateneo Law, he was part of a rigorous academic culture known for producing graduates who combine doctrinal mastery with a commitment to public interest law. This formative experience would later express itself in his early career work on human rights cases and pro bono representation.

Four years after passing the bar, Baddiri was selected for the highly competitive Fulbright Scholarship Program in 2004, awarded through the Philippine-American Educational Foundation (PAEF). The Fulbright brought him to the John F. Kennedy School of Government at Harvard University, where he completed a Master in Public Administration (MPA) in 2006.

The Harvard Kennedy School experience gave Baddiri fluency in the intersection of governance, public policy, and institutional reform, a toolkit he would draw on in his later work with the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos and, eventually, his judicial appointments.

Edilwasif Tapsiril Baddiri
Associate Justice Edilwasif Tapsiril Baddiri
Personal Information
Born: December 13, 1975
Ethnicity
Tausug (Sulu Archipelago)
Education
Bachelor of Laws (Ll.B.), Ateneo de Manila University School of Law (2000) Master in Public Administration (MPA), Harvard Kennedy School (2006)
Current Position
Associate Justice, Court of Appeals of the Philippines (2025-present)
Previous Positions
Commissioner, National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (2010-2015) Presiding Judge, RTC Branch 115, Pasay City (2015-2023) Executive Judge, RTC Pasay City
Affiliations

CAREER

Early Career

Baddiri began his professional life in the courts, working as a legal assistant at a Regional Trial Court, learning the day-to-day machinery of Philippine judicial procedure from the ground up.

He also stepped into the classroom early, teaching the Philippine Constitution at Ateneo de Zamboanga University, an institution with deep roots in the Muslim Mindanao region and a strong connection to the communities he came from.

He then moved into local governance, serving as a legislator in the province of Sulu, where he gained direct experience in the legislative and political challenges unique to the Bangsamoro south. Alongside this, he took on human rights cases and offered pro bono legal counsel to indigent clients, work that grounded his legal career in the lived realities of people who often had no one else to turn to.

National Commission on Muslim Filipinos

From 2010 to 2015, Baddiri served as a Commissioner of the National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF), representing the youth and civic sectors. The NCMF is the primary government agency mandated to preserve and develop the culture, tradition, institutions, and well-being of Filipino Muslims.

His five-year tenure at the NCMF gave him a panoramic view of Muslim Filipino affairs at the national level, and deepened his understanding of how Muslim communities interface with the Philippine state, from policy to practice.

The Judiciary: Trial Courts

Baddiri entered the judiciary in 2015, appointed as the Presiding Judge of Branch 115 of the Regional Trial Court in Pasay City, where he served until 2023.

He also handled judicial assignments in Catanauan, Quezon (Branch 96) and served as acting presiding judge in Makati City (Branch 142), demonstrating the kind of versatility and reliability that the Judicial and Bar Council looks for when evaluating judicial officers for elevation.

He was later designated as Executive Judge of the RTC in Pasay City, a role that carries administrative responsibility for the court's operations beyond his individual docket.

President, Philippine Muslim Judges Association (PMJA) Key Convener, Young Moro Professionals Network (YMPN)
Appointed By
President Ferdinand R. Marcos Jr. (February 24, 2025)
Oath Administered By
Chief Justice Alexander G. Gesmundo (April 11, 2025)
Notability
Fifth Tausug jurist to serve on the Philippine Court of Appeals; Fulbright Scholar and Harvard Kennedy School alumnus; leading advocate for Shari'ah integration into the Philippine judicial system.
Known For
Bangsamoro legal representation at the appellate level; presidency of the Philippine Muslim Judges Association; championing Shari'ah court modernization; civic leadership through the Young Moro Professionals Network.
Pull Quote
"A Tausug from the shores of Sulu, a jurist shaped by Ateneo and Harvard, and a voice for the Bangsamoro people at the highest levels of Philippine law."

Throughout his time on the trial bench, Baddiri was known for applying careful legal reasoning alongside a sensitivity to the social dimensions of the cases before him, a quality rooted in his background in human rights advocacy and public service.

Court of Appeals

On February 24, 2025, President Ferdinand Marcos Jr. appointed Baddiri as Associate Justice of the Court of Appeals of the Philippines, filling the seat vacated by the retirement of Justice Edwin D. Sorongon.

He took his oath of office on April 11, 2025, in a ceremony before Chief Justice Alexander G. Gesmundo at the Supreme Court, formalizing his elevation to the second-highest tier of the Philippine judicial hierarchy.

The appointment was met with celebration across the Bangsamoro legal community, who saw in it not just a personal achievement but a recognition of Muslim Filipino competence and leadership at the national appellate level.

INSTITUTIONAL CONTRIBUTIONS

Philippine Muslim Judges Association (PMJA)

Baddiri serves as President of the Philippine Muslim Judges Association (PMJA), an organization of Muslim magistrates working within the Philippine justice system.

Under his leadership, the PMJA has worked closely with the Supreme Court's Strategic Plan for Judicial Innovations (SPJI) 2022-2027 to bridge the longstanding gap between the regular civil court system and the Shari'ah courts of Muslim Mindanao. He has consistently championed the modernization and broader integration of Shari'ah justice into the Philippine legal framework, arguing that a just legal system must be one that Muslim Filipinos can access in ways that respect their faith and legal traditions.

Young Moro Professionals Network (YMPN)

Baddiri is one of the key conveners of the Young Moro Professionals Network (YMPN), a civic initiative dedicated to ethics, public service, and youth empowerment within the Bangsamoro community.

The YMPN reflects a generation of Muslim Filipino professionals who see civic leadership not as a departure from their identity but as an expression of it. Baddiri's involvement signals his commitment to mentoring and building pipelines for the next generation of Bangsamoro leaders in law, governance, and public life.

Legal Academia and Scholarship

Baddiri has served as a law professor, teaching Political Law, Criminal Procedure, and Public International Law at Manuel S. Enverga University Foundation School of Law, among other institutions.

He has also written on the complex relationships between the Bangsamoro people, the national government, and the evolving peace process, contributing to the scholarly conversation on how law can serve as a tool for inclusion rather than a mechanism of exclusion.

His scholarship reflects a consistent orientation: making the Philippine legal system more responsive to the realities and rights of Muslim Filipino communities.

LEGACY

Justice Edilwasif Tapsiril Baddiri occupies a historically significant place in the Bangsamoro legal tradition as the fifth Tausug jurist to reach the Court of Appeals, following in the footsteps of landmark Muslim magistrates including Justices Assali S. Isnani, Jainal D. Rasul, Omar U. Amin, and Hakim Abdulwahid.

His career arc tells a compelling story about what is possible when an individual from a historically marginalized community combines intellectual excellence with public service. From the shores of Sulu to the halls of Ateneo, from Cambridge, Massachusetts to the Court of Appeals in Manila, Baddiri has navigated and mastered some of the most demanding institutions the Philippines and the United States have to offer, while keeping his Tausug identity and Islamic faith at the center of who he is.

For the Bangsamoro people, his presence on the appellate bench is more than symbolic. It signals a slow but meaningful expansion of representation in the national justice system, the kind of institutional inclusion that shapes how laws are interpreted and how justice is delivered to communities that have too often felt invisible within it.

RECOGNITION

- Fulbright Scholarship recipient (2004), awarded through the Philippine-American Educational Foundation (PAEF)
- Formally recognized by the Muslim Lawyers of ZAMBASULTA for his integrity and swift progression through the judicial hierarchy
- Celebrated by the Fulbright Philippines Commission upon his oath-taking as Court of Appeals Associate Justice (April 2025)
- Honored by Manuel S. Enverga University Foundation as a distinguished faculty member and alumnus of the School of Law

CHALLENGES

Baddiri's career has unfolded against the backdrop of a Philippine legal system that has historically underrepresented Muslim Filipinos at the appellate level, whether in terms of numbers, institutional voice, or cultural sensitivity in judicial decision-making.

Navigating that system as a full-blooded Tausug from Sulu required not only legal acumen but also a capacity for bridging two worlds: the Bangsamoro south and the Metro Manila legal establishment. His work in the PMJA reflects an ongoing effort to address structural gaps, particularly the disconnect between civil and Shari'ah courts that affects Muslim litigants on a daily basis.

His elevation to the Court of Appeals places him in a position where his every decision will be watched with particular interest, both by those who celebrate his appointment and by those who continue to ask whether the Philippine judiciary is truly capable of meaningful reform in its approach to Muslim Filipino affairs.

SEE ALSO

- Court of Appeals of the Philippines

- Philippine Muslim Judges Association
- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos
- Tausug people
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Shari'ah courts in the Philippines
- Fulbright Program in the Philippines
- Ateneo de Manila University School of Law
- Harvard Kennedy School

REFERENCES

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